A CREATIVE COUPLING

If you are looking to double the fun and make things twice as nice, then deep dive into architects Sonali Bhagwati and Sohrab Dalal's interesting design journey

By RIDHI KALE

Almost every interview with architect Sonali Bhagwati mentions her CEPT journey about how she saw the university and decided to study architecture. But, that's only partly true. "I honestly didn't think of doing anything but architecture but without knowing what architecture was all about. When I went to Baroda, and I took the entrance test for the MS University's architectural department, it was all about maths, physics and chemistry; and I said, I've had it. I'm here to escape this, and this has just come back to haunt me," says Bhagwati who is the co-founder and president of DPA (DesignPlus Architecture).

Post the entrance, since she and her friend were close to Ahmedabad, they decided to go there and check out CEPT University. "When we walked into CEPT that's when I said yes, I not only want to do architecture, but I want to do it right here. That's the impact BV Doshi's building had on a 17-year-old, which I consider a biggest tribute to the architect," explains Bhagwati. Later Doshi turned into her mentor, guide, friend and philosopher.

Nevertheless, that makes you wonder how did she find herself living and working in Delhi-NCR? "I have grown up in Delhi, it has been my city, in fact, I lived in central Delhi for the first 25 years of my life," says Bhagwati. That's not where her Delhi-connect ends. She did her thesis on Kashmiri Gate and even today when she opens the papers, she actually looks for what city development is happening. One of Bhagwati's biggest grouse with Delhi has always been that everything is so unplanned and is therefore always ready to offer the city she loves solutions for better city planning. "After CEPT, I came back to Delhi and moved to Greater Kailash, where I started my practice along with my partner and husband Sohrab Dalal."

Bhagwati met Dalal and 17 and the two quickly figured they work well together. For her he is best friend, business partner, and spouse, all wrapped in one. "After graduation, Sonali worked in Paris for a year, while I worked in Sydney, Australia. And



Photograph by RAJWANT RAWAT